

The Same Psalm

I have sung the Old Hundredth all my life. I don't remember learning it. The organ starts and the words are already there, ahead of me, the way your own phone number is there before you've thought about it.

*All people that on earth do dwell,
sing to the Lord with cheerful voice.*

We sang it in a mournful tone. I stood next to my mother. It was the last thing — end of the service, everyone standing, and then out into the afternoon.

I have also sung Psalm 100 at the other end of a morning, years later, with the music going and hands up and the whole place loud.

*I will enter His gates with thanksgiving in my heart,
I will enter His courts with praise.¹*

That was Thanksgiving. That was how we started.

It took me a long time to notice they were the same psalm.

Psalm 100 is short. Five verses. Inside those five verses it gives seven orders.

Shout.

Serve.

Come.

Know.

Enter.

Give thanks.

Bless.

Six of those are things you do with your body. You can watch someone do them. One of them you can't see from outside, and I'll come back to it.

Every one is plural. Not one of them is addressed to an individual.

And they are not addressed to Israel. The psalm says *all the earth*.

Everyone. Kethe read that in 1561 and put it into English as *all people that on earth do dwell*, which is what I had been singing without hearing it.

I have noticed something about where the psalm gets used. With my mother it came at the end, the last thing before the doors. Years later it came at the start, the thing that got the morning going. Both are right, and the psalm allows both, because it is built as an approach. You begin outside. There are gates in it, and courts past the gates. Sing it at the start and you are arriving. Sing it at the finish and you are being sent. Where you stand when you sing decides which way you are facing.

The order you can't see from outside is *know*.

You can watch a person shout. You can watch them come in through a gate. You cannot watch them know something. And the psalm puts that one in the middle of the six you can watch, as though it belongs with them rather than above them.

Know that the LORD, he is God! It is he who made us, and we are his; we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.

The Hebrew word is *yada'*. It is not the knowing of facts. You do not *yada'* a phone number. It is what you have with a person you have lived alongside long enough to be sure of them – you know what they will do, because you know them. So the psalm is not saying think about this. It is saying be sure of him.

Then it says what to be sure of, and here the text does something unusual.

Hebrew was written without vowels. A handful of words came down the centuries in two forms: the way it stood written on the page, and the way it had always been read aloud. The scribes would not choose between them. They passed on both.

Verse 3 is one of those. One letter is different. The two letters sound exactly the same when spoken, so nobody hearing it would know there was a question.

Written: *he made us, and not we ourselves.*

Read aloud: *he made us, and we are his.*

One says you did not make yourself. The other says you belong to him.

The English above has chosen the second. Most modern versions do. The scribes could have settled it too. They had every opportunity. They handed both down side by side instead.

And *made* here is not the making of Genesis. It is the making of a people – he made us into something that was not there before. The line that follows says so: *we are his people, and the sheep of his pasture.* That was Israel's sentence about Israel. The psalm has just given it to all the earth.

Every order in this psalm is plural. English cannot show you that. Our *you* is the same word whether one person is standing there or ten thousand, so we read the psalm the way we read most things, as something said to us personally, and we cannot tell that it isn't.

He made us is not each of us made separately. It is a people made. The sheep are a flock. The gates are wide and the courts are full, and nobody enters them alone.

Enter his gates with thanksgiving, and his courts with praise!

The heading of the psalm is one word, and most English Bibles keep it: *A Psalm for giving thanks*. In Hebrew it is *todah*, and it is the only psalm in the book with that heading.

Todah is not a feeling. It is a sacrifice. Leviticus sets out how it worked: an animal, and bread brought with it, and one rule that changes everything — it had to be eaten the same day.² Nothing kept back. Nothing left for the morning.

Which meant you could not finish it. Not one household, not in a day. You had to go and find people.

So the thank-offering was built so that it spoiled if you kept it to yourself.

That is the thing you carry through the gates. English gives us *thanksgiving*, and what we hear is a mood — a warm one, a private one, something you can have on your own in a car. The psalm means a shared meal with a deadline.

Then the psalm gives its second reason.

For the LORD is good; his steadfast love endures forever, and his faithfulness to all generations.

The first reason, back in verse 3, was who he is. This one is what he is like.

The word behind *steadfast love* is *hesed*. It is love that has given its word and does not take it back.

The word beside it is *emunah*. Firmness. The quality of a thing that stays put.

It is not a second item on a list. It is the first word looked at over time. *Hesed* forever, *emunah* to generation and generation – the same love, watched long enough to see it outlast the people who first received it. My mother had it before I did. It reached me, and it had not weakened on the way.

That is the reason for the seven orders. Not that we have worked something up. He is good. That is all, and the psalm thinks it is enough.

DOXOLOGY

Kethe put the psalm into English metre in 1561 and it has been sung ever since – at the end of services, at funerals, at the close of days, by people who have no idea who he was. The tune carries it. The words arrive before you have decided to say them.

That is what a doxology does. You do not compose it. You are handed it, already made, by people who sang it before you and will not hear you singing it now.

*All people that on earth do dwell,
sing to the Lord with cheerful voice;
him serve with mirth, his praise forth tell,
come ye before him and rejoice.*

*The Lord, ye know, is God indeed;
without our aid he did us make;
we are his folk, he doth us feed,
and for his sheep he doth us take.*

*O enter then his gates with praise,
approach with joy his courts unto;
praise, laud, and bless his name always,
for it is seemly so to do.*

*For why? the Lord our God is good,
his mercy is for ever sure;
his truth at all times firmly stood,
and shall from age to age endure.*

Without our aid he did us make. Kethe sang the reading the scribes would not choose.

He kept six of the seven. *Shout* became *sing*. *Know* stopped being an order at all and turned into an aside – *the Lord, ye know, is God indeed* – the way a thing everyone already agrees on stops being said outright.

The one he let go was *give thanks*.³

The chorus we sang with our hands up kept it.

I will enter His gates with thanksgiving in my heart.

1 "He Has Made Me Glad," Leona Von Brethorst, 1976. The Old Hundredth stanzas quoted here and below are William Kethe's metrical Psalm 100, first printed 1560–61, public domain. They follow the familiar sung text rather than Kethe's first printing: he wrote *him serve with fear*, and the *Psalms of David in Meeter* (Edinburgh, 1650) altered it to *him serve with mirth*, which is closer to the psalm's *serve the LORD with gladness* and is what has been sung since.

2 Leviticus 7:15 requires the thank-offering to be eaten on the day it is offered, with nothing left until morning. The next two verses allow a second day for votive and freewill offerings – the same-day rule belongs to the *todah* alone.

3 Of the psalm's seven, Kethe keeps *serve*, *come*, *enter* and *bless* outright, renders *shout* as *sing*, and leaves *know* standing as a parenthesis rather than a command. *Give thanks* is the one that goes: verse 4's *with thanksgiving* becomes *with praise*, and *give thanks to him* becomes *praise, laud*. He adds imperatives of his own along the way – *tell*, *rejoice*, *approach*, *laud* – so the stanzas carry more orders than the psalm does, just not the same seven.

This article did not begin with artificial intelligence. It began with years of ministry, reading, prayer, suffering, and conversation.

During its development, AI became a conversation partner. It challenged assumptions, tested arguments, suggested structures, and helped refine expression. Many of the words here emerged through that dialogue.

The experiences, convictions, interpretations, and conclusions remain my own.